

Rule of Life

*The Ancient Art of Forming a Soul in an Age Built to
Deform It*

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LIVEWELL BY JAMES BELL

*Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by
the renewal of your mind.*

— Romans 12:2

Introduction: You Are Being Formed

Reach for your phone tomorrow morning before your feet touch the floor, the way you did this morning and the way you will the morning after, and understand that you have just performed a religious act. Not a casual one. A practice, repeated daily, at the most vulnerable hinge of your day, the moment between sleep and waking when the soul is soft. You did not decide that the first voice you would hear each day would be the feed. You drifted into it, and the drift became a habit, and the habit is now forming you, quietly and relentlessly, into a particular kind of person, and you never chose the person.

This is the thing the modern Christian has the hardest time seeing, because we have been taught to believe that we are essentially thinkers, that we are what we believe, that the Christian life is mostly a matter of getting the right ideas into our heads and the right feelings into our hearts on Sunday. James K. A. Smith has spent a career arguing, after Augustine, that this is precisely wrong, that we are not first thinkers but lovers, that what orients a human life is not what we think but what we love, and that our loves are not chosen by our minds but trained by our bodies, formed by what we do over and over until it becomes the automatic motion of the heart. We are, all of us, what we repeatedly do. And the things we repeatedly do are mostly things we never chose to be doing.

So look honestly at what is forming you. The secular age is not a neutral space where you happen to hold your private beliefs. It is a vast and sophisticated machine of formation, and it has its own liturgies, as relentless as any monk's. The phone is a prayer book

you consult a hundred times a day. The store, online and endless, is a temple where you go to be told that you are what you acquire. The feed is a catechism, teaching you hour by hour what to want, whom to envy, what to fear, what to be outraged by. None of it announces itself as discipleship. All of it is discipleship. You are being formed every waking hour, with a patience and a consistency that ought to terrify us, into a creature of acquisition and distraction and grievance and self, and the formation is working, and most of us cannot even feel it happening.

Against this, the apostle Paul says a thing that turns out to be the most practical sentence in the New Testament. Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewal of your mind. Notice that he does not offer a third option. He does not say you may remain neutral, unformed, a free agent floating above the pressures of your age. There is no such person. You will be conformed or you will be transformed, pressed into the world's mold or remade into Christ's, and the only question is which, because the formation is happening either way. The terror and the hope of the Christian life are the same fact. You are being formed. The question is by what, and into whose image.

And here the modern church stands embarrassed, because it has almost nothing to offer in answer. For two thousand years the church carried a whole technology of formation, an ordered set of practices the ancients called a rule of life, the hours and the fasts and the silence and the Sabbath and the calendar and the disciplines, all of it engineered to do exactly what Paul commanded, to take an ordinary person and slowly, deliberately, bodily form them into a saint. And we threw it away. We called it legalism, or works-righteousness, or dead ritual, or a Catholic relic, and we kept a thin religion of sincere belief and Sunday

feeling, and then we wondered why that thin religion could not stand against an age that was catechizing our bodies every hour of every day. This book is an attempt to go back into the storehouse we abandoned and bring out the old tools, not from nostalgia, but because they are the only things strong enough for what we are up against. You are being formed. It is time to choose by what.

Chapter One: The Liturgies You Did Not Choose

Let us be precise about how formation actually works, because the church's whole strategy went wrong at exactly this point. We have assumed, in the modern West, that people are changed mainly by information. Get someone the right beliefs, the right doctrine, the right worldview, persuade their mind, and the life will follow. So we built a Christianity of messages, of sermons and books and studies and conferences, an enormous apparatus for delivering correct ideas into Christian heads, and we are mystified that so many heads full of correct ideas sit atop lives indistinguishable from the world around them. The information went in. The life did not change. And the reason is that information was never what formed us in the first place.

What forms us is liturgy, by which I mean not only the order of a worship service but any repeated, embodied practice that trains our loves by aiming our bodies at some vision of the good life over and over until we want it without deciding to. Augustine saw sixteen hundred years ago that the human being is at bottom a lover, that we are defined and directed by what we love most, and that the great question of a life is the ordering of its loves. And our loves are not lectured into us. They are practiced into us. You come to love what you repeatedly do, what you give your time and your attention and your body to, day after day, below the level of conscious choice. This is why a person can sincerely believe all the right things about God and money and still have a heart that loves money, because his beliefs were trained on Sunday and his loves were trained by ten thousand

hours in the temple of acquisition.

Now see the secular age for what it is. It is not chiefly a set of arguments against Christianity, though it has those. It is a set of liturgies more powerful than any argument, practices so woven into ordinary life that we perform them without ever recognizing them as formation. Consider the genius of the smartphone as a discipleship device. It trains you to reach for it in every moment of stillness, so that you lose the capacity to be alone with your own thoughts or with God. It trains you to want the next thing, the next image, the next notification, in an endless loop engineered by people who understand your loves better than you do. It catechizes you in comparison, in outrage, in the conviction that your worth is a number other people assign you. No one sat you down and argued you into these loves. You practiced your way into them, a few minutes at a time, until they became the automatic motions of your heart.

And against liturgies that work on the body every hour, a faith that lives only in the head does not stand a chance. This is the diagnosis the modern church has refused, because it indicts our entire approach. We have tried to form disciples the way you would educate a student, through content, and the secular age has formed its devotees the way you actually form a human being, through practice, and the secular age is winning in a rout. You cannot think your way to holiness while your habits are being catechized by Babylon. You cannot hold the right beliefs hard enough to overcome a body that has been trained, all week, to love the wrong things. The renewal Paul commands does not happen in the mind alone, because the mind is not where the trouble is. The trouble is in the loves, and the loves are trained by what the body repeatedly does.

You were never going to be formed by your beliefs alone, because no one is. You are formed by your practices, and while you were guarding your doctrine, the age was quietly training your loves through your thumbs.

So the recovery has to begin with a confession that sounds strange in a Protestant mouth, the confession that we need a discipline, an ordered set of practices, a counter-liturgy strong enough to retrain the loves that Babylon has been training all along. The early Christians knew this in their bones. They did not assume that believing the gospel was enough to withstand a pagan empire whose every rhythm pulled the other way. They built a whole alternative way of life, a pattern of practices that formed them into a people the empire could not assimilate. They had a rule. And the recovery of the Christian soul in our own pagan age begins with the recovery of that ancient and unfashionable word, the word we have spent five centuries learning to despise.

Chapter Two: The Rule

Around the year 530, in the ruins of a collapsing Roman world, a man named Benedict wrote a short document for the communities of monks gathering around him, and he called it simply a rule, a regula. He apologized for it, called it a little rule for beginners, and it went on to become one of the most influential texts in the history of Western civilization, the pattern that ordered monastic life for fifteen hundred years and, not incidentally, preserved the learning and the faith of the West through the long centuries after Rome fell. The monks who lived by Benedict's rule kept the lamp burning in the dark, and they did it not because they were geniuses or heroes but because they had a rule, an ordered way of life that formed ordinary, flawed people into something durable across generations.

The word repays attention. A regula was originally a straight piece of wood, a ruler, and behind Benedict's use of it stands the image that has helped people understand a rule of life ever since, the image of a trellis. A trellis is a structure on which a living thing grows. The vine does not experience the trellis as a prison. The trellis is what allows the vine to climb toward the light instead of sprawling on the ground and rotting. A rule of life is a trellis for the soul, an external structure of practices on which an interior life can grow upward, and without it the soul does what an untrellised vine does, which is not to run free but to collapse into a heap and produce nothing. We have the freedom exactly backwards. We think structure is the enemy of life. The gardener knows it is the condition of it.

But the modern Protestant hears the word rule and flinches, and

we have to deal honestly with the flinch, because it is not entirely wrong. We hear rule and we think law, and we think of earning, of trying to win God's favor by our performance, of the dead religion of the Pharisee checking boxes, and we are right to reject all of that, because the gospel is grace and we are saved by what Christ has done and not by our practices. But this is a confusion, and clearing it up is the hinge of the whole book. A rule of life is not how you earn God's love. It is how you arrange your life so that you are standing in the place where grace falls. It is not the engine of your salvation. It is the trellis on which the life God gives you can grow. The Christian does not pray and fast and keep the Sabbath in order to make God love him. He does these things because they are how a human being is formed, how the love already given gets down into the body and the habits and the loves, and to refuse all discipline in the name of grace is like refusing to plant a garden in the name of trusting God for vegetables.

Paul reached for an image our therapeutic age has lost entirely. Train yourself for godliness, he told Timothy, and the word he used is the word for athletic training, for the disciplined, repetitive, often unpleasant work of the gymnasium. For while bodily training is of some value, he goes on, godliness is of value in every way. The ancient church took this with full seriousness and called the spiritual disciplines *askesis*, the root of our word *ascetic*, meaning training, exercise, the deliberate practice by which an athlete or a soldier or a saint is made. No one drifts into excellence at anything. The musician does not wait to feel inspired before practicing scales. The athlete does not train only when motivated. And the Christian who waits to pray until he feels like praying, who treats every discipline as optional and every practice as legalism, is not free. He is simply being formed by whatever does have a rule, and in our age what has a rule is

the feed, the cart, and the endless scroll. The only question is whose rule will form you, and a person without a rule of his own has already answered it. He has chosen Babylon's.

A rule of life is not how you earn God's love. It is how you put yourself in the path of it. We called structure legalism and called our formlessness freedom, and all the while we were being formed, rigorously, by the rule we pretended not to have.

So to take up a rule is not to return to bondage. It is to stop being formed by accident. It is to make, once and deliberately, the decisions about prayer and rest and attention and feasting that you would otherwise have to make a hundred times a day and would lose nearly every time, because in the moment the feed is always more immediately appealing than the office of prayer. The rule decides in advance, in a clear hour, what the weak and distracted self will not be able to decide in the moment. That is not legalism. That is the wisdom of every person who has ever actually changed, who knew that the will alone is too weak to fight ten thousand daily liturgies and so enlisted habit, structure, and rule on the side of the love it wanted to grow. And the oldest and most basic of those structures is the one that takes the day itself, the ordinary unrepeatable day, and bends it back toward God.

Chapter Three: The Hours

The most ancient and most basic of the Christian disciplines is also the one that strikes the modern person as the strangest, the practice of fixed-hour prayer, of stopping at set times through the day to turn deliberately toward God. It is older than the church. The Psalmist sang, seven times a day I praise you for your righteous rules, and at evening and morning and noon I utter my complaint. Daniel, in exile in Babylon, prayed three times a day toward Jerusalem with his windows open, and would not stop though it cost him the lions' den. The first Christians, formed in this Jewish rhythm, prayed at the hours, and the monastic tradition gathered the practice into the daily office, the cycle of prayers that punctuated the day from before dawn to the prayer called compline at its close, so that the whole of time was strung on a thread of prayer.

Understand what the hours are for, because it is not what we assume. We assume prayer is mainly about getting things from God, or about a warm experience of his presence, and so we pray when we need something or when we feel moved. The hours are built on a different logic entirely. They are not about feeling. They are about formation. To stop at fixed times, whether or not you feel like it, whether or not anything seems to happen, is to train the soul toward God the way scales train the hands of the pianist, by repetition below the level of inspiration. You pray the hours on the dry days and the distracted days and the days you feel nothing, and the not-feeling is not a failure of the practice, it is part of how the practice works, because you are not chasing an experience, you are bending a life, and a life is bent by what it

does consistently, not by what it feels occasionally.

And the hours go to war with the single most powerful liturgy of our age, the liturgy of the feed, precisely over the territory of the day. The contest is plain. The first thing you turn to in the morning will form you. The thing you reach for in every idle moment will form you. The voice that fills the gaps of your day, at the red light, in the line, in the pause between tasks, will form you. The age has captured all of those moments, the morning and the gaps and the hinges of the day, and filled them with the scroll. The hours are the church's ancient claim on exactly that territory. They say that the morning belongs to God before it belongs to the feed, that the pauses of the day are for prayer and not for the endless refresh, that the close of the day is sealed with thanksgiving and not with one more hour of the glowing screen in the soft and vulnerable dark.

You do not have to take on the full monastic office to begin. The point is not the precise form but the principle, that the day must be ordered around God on purpose, with set times and set prayers that do not depend on your fluctuating motivation, or it will be ordered around something else by default. Begin with the morning, before the phone, with a psalm and the Lord's Prayer. Add a pause at midday. Seal the night with a prayer of examination and rest. Let the shape grow as it will. What matters is the recovery of the ancient conviction that time is not neutral, that a day is a thing that gets formed, and that a Christian orders his hours toward God deliberately because he knows that if he does not, the most sophisticated attention-machine ever built will be glad to order them for him, and it will not be forming him toward the kingdom.

The day will be ordered by something. The ancient

church ordered it by prayer at fixed hours. We have let it be ordered by the feed, and then we ask why God feels so distant, when we have given the hinges of every day to a machine built to keep him out.

The hours train the soul through time, but the human being is not only a soul in time. We are bodies, stubborn and appetite-driven bodies, and the ancients knew that no formation that ignored the body could ever go deep, because the body has its own loves and its own liturgies and will quietly run the whole person if it is never disciplined. And so alongside the prayer of the hours the church developed a set of practices aimed directly at the body and its hungers, practices we have nearly lost, the twin disciplines of the fast and the feast.

Chapter Four: The Table and the Fast

We are not souls that happen to be carrying bodies around. We are embodied creatures, body and soul together, and what we do with the body forms the whole person, which is why the most physical of the disciplines, fasting, was for most of Christian history simply assumed, and why its near-total disappearance from the modern church is such a telling loss. The early Christians fasted regularly, often twice a week, and the desert fathers fasted with a severity that alarms us. They did this not because they hated the body or thought it evil, that was the heresy they fought, but because they understood something about the body that we have forgotten, that a body which has never once been told no will rule the soul like a tyrant, and that the small, deliberate, repeated practice of denying the body even good things is how a person learns that they are not the helpless servant of their own appetites.

Consider what fasting actually trains. We live in the most appetite-indulgent civilization in human history, an economy built entirely on the principle of immediate gratification, the next purchase one click away, the next bite always available, every craving met before it can even fully form into a want. This is not neutral. It is a liturgy, and it forms us into people who cannot tolerate the smallest delay, the slightest hunger, the briefest discomfort, people whose default motion is to satisfy the appetite the instant it appears. And the Christian who fasts is doing something quietly revolutionary against that whole formation. He is teaching his body, in the most direct possible way, that the

appetite can be felt and not obeyed, that hunger is survivable, that he is not the slave of his cravings but their master under God. You cannot learn that from a sermon. You learn it the way the body learns anything, by doing it, by being hungry on purpose and discovering you did not die.

I should name the danger, because the tradition does, relentlessly. Fasting is the discipline most easily corrupted into pride, the one the Pharisee paraded and Jesus warned about, the one that can make a person insufferable and self-righteous and secretly convinced that his empty stomach has put God in his debt. The desert fathers, who fasted more than anyone, were also the fiercest critics of fasting done for show or pushed to the point of spiritual vanity, and they insisted that a humble meal eaten in love was worth more than a proud fast. So the discipline comes with its own guardrail, that it is done in secret, before God and not before people, and that its aim is not the punishment of the body but the freedom of the soul. Done rightly, it is not grim. It is the strange light feeling of a person discovering they need far less than they thought.

And fasting has a twin that we have lost just as badly, which is feasting, the rightly ordered enjoyment of good gifts. The same tradition that fasted twice a week also kept feasts with real joy, the Lord's Supper at the center and the great festivals of the Christian year around it, because the goal of the disciplined life was never the rejection of God's good world but the right enjoyment of it, freed from the compulsive overconsumption that cannot actually enjoy anything because it is never present and never satisfied. Babylon does not know how to feast. It only knows how to consume, endlessly and joylessly, never tasting because already reaching for the next thing. The church knows how to feast precisely because it knows how to fast, because the

body that has learned to say no can finally say a real and grateful yes, can sit at the table and taste the bread and know it as gift. The fast and the feast together form a person who is neither enslaved to appetite nor afraid of joy, which is to say a free person, which is a thing Babylon cannot produce.

A faith that never fasts leaves the body exactly as Babylon trained it, unable to bear the smallest hunger, ruled by every craving. The body that learns to say no is the only one that can finally feast, because it is the only one actually present at the table.

The disciplines of the body order our hungers, and the hours order our days, but there is a larger rhythm the ancients built into the week itself, a practice so central that God wrote it into the Ten Commandments and so neglected that it is the one commandment modern Christians break proudly and call it devotion. It is the practice of stopping. The Sabbath.

Chapter Five: Sabbath

Of the ten commandments God carved in stone, nine are repeated and reinforced throughout the New Testament, and one is quietly treated by most modern Christians as expired, optional, a quaint relic of an older dispensation we have happily outgrown. It is, of course, the one we find most inconvenient, the fourth, the longest of the ten, the command to keep the Sabbath. Remember the Sabbath day, to keep it holy. Six days you shall labor and do all your work, but the seventh day is a Sabbath to the Lord your God. On it you shall not do any work. We have decided, without ever quite deciding, that this one does not apply to us, and our exhaustion, our anxiety, our inability to rest, our compulsive productivity even in our leisure, are the daily evidence of what that decision has cost us.

The rabbi Abraham Joshua Heschel wrote the most beautiful book on the Sabbath of the last century, and his central image has never been improved. The Sabbath, he said, is a palace in time. We are good at building cathedrals in space, sacred places we can enter, but the Sabbath is a cathedral built not of stone but of hours, a sanctuary in time itself, into which a person enters not by traveling anywhere but by stopping. One day in seven, the Jew and then the Christian was to cease, to lay down the work and the striving and the productivity, and to dwell in a palace made of rested time, and Heschel understood that this was not a burden imposed on freedom but the very shape of freedom itself, a regular, embodied, weekly declaration that a human being is more than what he produces.

Because that is what the Sabbath says with the body, and it says

it against the loudest lie of our economy. Our age tells us, every hour, that we are what we produce, that our worth is our output, that to stop is to fall behind and to fall behind is to fail. It is a brutal gospel, and it has made us a people who cannot rest even when we are resting, who bring the phone to the vacation and the email to the dinner table and the low background hum of productivity-anxiety to every moment that was supposed to be free. And the Sabbath cuts directly across it. To stop for a whole day, to refuse the work, to let the world go on turning without my anxious management of it, is to declare with my entire body that the world is held by God and not by me, that I am a creature and not a machine, that my worth was settled by my Creator and not by my calendar. It is the most countercultural thing a modern person can do, and it is a commandment.

And notice what reason God gives for it, because it goes to the heart of everything this book is about. When God repeats the Sabbath command in Deuteronomy, he ties it to the exodus. You shall remember that you were a slave in the land of Egypt, and the Lord your God brought you out. Keep the Sabbath, in other words, because you are not a slave anymore. Slaves do not get a day off. Slaves work without ceasing at the pleasure of their masters, and a people that cannot stop, that dares not rest, that is driven by an anxiety it cannot name to keep producing and keep consuming and keep scrolling without pause, is a people that has been enslaved again, whatever it calls itself. The Sabbath is the weekly act by which the free person remembers, in his body, that he has been set free, and refuses to return to the brickyard. We broke the Sabbath in the name of freedom and productivity, and we have never been more exhausted or more enslaved. The command we discarded was the rest we are dying for.

A people that cannot stop has not been freed. It has

only changed masters. God commanded the Sabbath to a nation of former slaves so that their bodies would never forget they were no longer in Egypt, and we, who will not stop for anything, have quietly marched ourselves back in.

The Sabbath stops the week, the hours bend the day, the fast disciplines the body, and underneath all of them runs a quieter discipline still, one the desert fathers fled to the wilderness to find, one that our age has engineered out of human life so thoroughly that most people now go their whole lives without ever once tasting it. It is the discipline of silence, and the solitude in which a soul is finally left alone with God.

Chapter Six: Silence and the Cell

In the late third century, men and women began to do a strange and dramatic thing. They went out into the deserts of Egypt and Syria to be alone with God. We call them the desert fathers and mothers, and the movement they began would shape Christian spirituality forever, but their basic insight was simple and is desperately needed now. They believed that a person could not be formed in the noise and distraction of the world, that the soul needed silence the way the body needs sleep, and that only in solitude, stripped of the endless voices and demands of the crowd, could a person finally come face to face with God and with the truth about themselves. So they sought the silence, and the small bare rooms they prayed in, which they called cells, became the most famous schoolrooms in the history of the soul.

There is a saying that comes down to us from those deserts, attributed to one of the elders, and it is the whole chapter in a sentence. A young monk came to an old one asking for a word, for wisdom, for some teaching that would form him, and the old man said, go, sit in your cell, and your cell will teach you everything. Sit still. Be silent. Stay in the place of solitude long enough, and it will do the forming, because in the silence everything you have been using noise to avoid will rise to the surface, the boredom you medicate with the phone, the anxieties you drown in distraction, the self you have never actually had to sit with, and finally, underneath all of it, the God who was always speaking in a voice too quiet to hear over the noise you kept manufacturing. The cell teaches everything because the cell takes away everything you were hiding behind.

Now measure our age against that. We have built a civilization with no cell and no silence, a world engineered so that a person need never be alone with their own thoughts for more than a few seconds, ever again, for the rest of their life. The instant a gap of silence opens, at the red light, in the elevator, in the bed before sleep, the hand finds the phone and the gap is filled. We have made silence not merely rare but actively frightening, a thing we flee, because we have lost the capacity to sit in it, and a generation raised on constant input is losing the ability even to be bored, which is the doorway to imagination and reflection and prayer. And a soul that can never be silent can never be formed at any depth, because the deep formation happens in the quiet, in the long unstimulated hours the desert fathers sought and we have abolished. Babylon fills every silence on purpose. It is afraid of what you might hear.

For it was in the silence, the Scriptures keep insisting, that God was most clearly found. Elijah, fleeing for his life, met God not in the wind that tore the mountains nor in the earthquake nor in the fire, but after the fire, in the sound of a low whisper, the still small voice that you cannot hear over your own noise. This is the discipline that frightens us most and that we need most, the deliberate practice of turning off the input, of sitting in the silence we have spent our whole lives avoiding, of being alone, without the phone, without the noise, long enough and often enough that the surface of the soul goes still and we can finally hear the whisper. It need not be a desert. It can be a quiet room, an early hour, a walk without the earbuds, a deliberate and regular appointment with silence. But it must be real, and it must be chosen, because everything in the age is built to prevent it, and the soul that cannot bear to be silent and alone has lost the one condition in which it could be most deeply formed, and most surely met.

*A soul that cannot bear silence cannot bear God,
because he speaks mostly in the quiet we have engineered
out of our lives. The desert fathers fled to the silence to
be formed. We flee from it, and wonder why we feel so
unformed and so unmet.*

The hours order the day, the Sabbath orders the week, and there is one more great rhythm the church laid over time, the largest of them, that orders the entire year and walks a person through the whole story of Christ from his coming to his reign, every twelve months, until the gospel is not merely believed but inhabited. It is the Christian calendar, and it is the church's answer to the question of who will own your sense of time itself.

Chapter Seven: The Calendar

Time is never neutral, and someone is always shaping it. The year you live through has a shape, a rhythm of seasons and high points and ordinary stretches, and that shape is forming you, teaching you what to anticipate and what to celebrate and what the story of a year is even about. Ask yourself honestly what shapes your year right now, and the answer for most of us is some combination of the commercial calendar and the cultural one, the retail seasons that begin earlier each year, the holidays defined mostly by what they sell, the rhythm of sales and shopping and the long secular festivals of consumption, with the sports seasons and the school year filling in the rest. That calendar is a catechism too. It teaches you that the year is a cycle of things to buy and games to watch, and it forms your imagination in its own image, year after year, whether you notice or not.

The ancient church built a rival calendar, and it is one of the most quietly powerful formation tools ever devised. The Christian year takes the entire story of Christ and lays it over the twelve months, so that a person walks through the whole gospel annually, not as information but as lived time. It begins in Advent, in waiting and longing in the dark for a coming light. It moves to Christmas and the staggering claim of God made flesh, and to Epiphany and the light going out to the nations. It descends into Lent, the long sober season of repentance and fasting in the wilderness, and down into the darkness of Holy Week and the cross. And then it breaks open into Easter, the resurrection, weeks of feasting and resurrection joy, and into

Pentecost and the coming of the Spirit, and then the long green stretch of Ordinary Time, the season of growth, before the cycle turns again toward Advent. To live this calendar is to have the gospel walked into your body once a year, every year, until its rhythms become the rhythms of your own soul.

See what this does that mere belief cannot. A Christian who only holds the gospel as a set of facts has it in his head. A Christian who lives the Christian year has it in his time, in his anticipation and his fasting and his feasting, in the very shape of his months. He learns to wait, really wait, through the weeks of Advent, and the waiting forms something in him that no sermon on patience could. He learns to grieve and repent through the long discipline of Lent, and the grief goes deeper than a single sad service could take it. He learns resurrection joy not as an idea but as a season he actually inhabits for weeks. The calendar takes the story we say we believe and makes us live inside it, over and over, until believing it and inhabiting it become the same thing, until the gospel is not something we know but something we are made of.

And this, like everything in this book, is finally a contest over formation, a question of which calendar will own your imagination. You will keep a calendar. You will order your year by something, anticipate something, structure your time around some story. The only question is whether it will be the story of Christ or the story the market is telling, whether your year will be shaped by Advent and Easter or by the shopping seasons and the streaming releases, whether the high points of your year will be the resurrection of the Son of God or the sales that bear the names of saints no one remembers. We let the mall keep our calendar, and then we are surprised that our imaginations are shaped like advertisements and our deepest seasonal feelings cluster around acquisition. To take up the Christian year is to

take the calendar back, to let the gospel rather than the market set the rhythm of our time, and so to be formed, month after month, by the only story worth ordering a life around.

You will order your year by some story. We handed our calendar to the market and let it walk us, every year, through the liturgy of acquisition. The church walks its people through the death and resurrection of God instead, until the gospel is not believed but inhabited.

The hours, the fast and the feast, the Sabbath, the silence, the calendar, all of these are the pieces of a rule of life, the trellis on which a soul can grow. But there is one thing left to say, the thing that keeps the whole project from curdling into exactly the disease it was meant to cure, and it is the truth that none of this can be done alone, and that the moment we try to do it alone, for ourselves, we have handed it back to the very enemy we were fighting.

Chapter Eight: A School for the Lord's Service

When Benedict introduced his rule, he described what he was establishing with a phrase that gathers up everything this book has tried to say. He was founding, he wrote, a school for the Lord's service. Not a self-improvement program. Not a private regimen of personal optimization. A school, which is a community of learning, and a service, which is an orientation away from the self toward God and others. The disciplines were never meant to be practiced by isolated individuals working privately on their own spiritual fitness. They were meant to be lived together, in a body, under a shared rule, over a long time, the way you cannot learn a language alone or become a soldier alone or be raised alone, because the deepest formation has always happened in community and never in isolation.

This matters more than it may seem, because there is a way of taking up everything I have described in this book that would poison all of it, and it is the way our age will immediately try to take it. The age will hear talk of practices and disciplines and formation and reach instantly for its native category, self-improvement, the optimization of the individual self, and it will turn the rule of life into one more self-help regimen, the spiritual version of the fitness tracker and the productivity system, a way for the sovereign self to become a better, more peaceful, more impressive version of itself. And the moment that happens, the disciplines have been captured by the exact enemy they were built to fight. A rule of life practiced to improve myself is just the religion of the self wearing a monk's robe. The practices do

not exist to make me a better me. They exist to put me to death and raise me into Christ, to decrease the self rather than optimize it, and a community is the great protection against the lie, because it is very hard to make your spiritual disciplines all about you when you are practicing them alongside other people whose needs keep interrupting your serenity.

Augustine gave the test that guards the whole enterprise, and we have met it before. The aim of every practice, he said, every reading of Scripture and every discipline, is the increase of the love of God and the love of neighbor, and any practice that does not serve that love, however rigorous, has gone wrong. So the rule of life is not finally about achieving a more disciplined self. It is about becoming, slowly, a more loving one, a person whose ordered prayers and fasts and silences are quietly forming them into someone who loves God more and loves their neighbor more, which is the only measure of formation the gospel will accept. If the hours and the fasts and the silence are making you more serene and less loving, more impressive and less kind, they have become Babylon's tools after all, and the only repair is to remember whom they were always for.

So I will end where the whole book has been pointing, with the truth that you are being formed right now, at this moment, by something, into someone, and that you will not escape the formation, only choose its source. Babylon has a rule of life, a thorough and patient and brilliantly engineered rule, the rule of the feed and the cart and the endless scroll, and it is forming you with a consistency and a devotion the church abandoned centuries ago, and it is winning, and most of its devotees do not even know they have joined an order. The ancient church offers another rule, older and slower and far less immediately gratifying, the rule of the hours and the table and the Sabbath

and the silence and the calendar, practiced not alone but in the body of Christ, aimed not at a better self but at the love of God. It will not transform you overnight. It will not feel dramatic. Most of its work will be invisible to you, the slow growth of a soul on a trellis, a long obedience in the same direction. But it is the only thing strong enough, and it is the inheritance we threw away, and it is waiting in the storehouse for any Christian with the nerve to go back in and pick it up. You are being formed. You have always been being formed. The only question the age will not let you ask is the one that decides everything. Into whose image, and by whose rule?